

WIN FOR DIVERSITY
Ali Fazal (right) with Gal Gadot in *Death on the Nile*

Actor Ali Fazal made his overseas debut in 2015 with a tiny role in the seventh instalment of *Fast & Furious*, one of Hollywood's biggest action franchises. A lot has changed since then. With American cinema making an active push for diversity, the range of roles available to non-white actors has broadened significantly. In *The Personal History of David Copperfield* (2019), it was Dev Patel who played the Dickensian protagonist. Denzel Washington plays Macbeth in Joel Coen's recent Shakespeare adaptation, and Disney has announced that a Latina actress, Rachel Zegler, will next be playing the part of Snow White.

In the upcoming adaptation of Agatha Christie's *Death on the Nile* (releasing in Indian theatres on February 11), Fazal's third international outing after period drama *Victoria & Abdul* (2017), he plays Andrew Katchadourian, a character, as the name suggests, not of Indian descent. Fazal says he was "flattered" that director Kenneth Branagh "took a chance" on him with the role, especially since it was played by the Oscar-winning actor George Kennedy in the film's 1978 version. "Our film is a perfect platform where you can have a diverse cast," says Fazal. "There's no mention of who is from where. It's a fictional world, so one can have a different gaze and [do] blind casting."

After the death of Irrfan Khan, Fazal joins a small pack of Indian actors who have started shuttling between India and abroad.

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"I have to be mindful of what I am choosing," he says. "It has to be the right stuff." *Death on the Nile*, an ensemble whodunit starring Gal Gadot (*Wonder Woman*, 2017), Letitia Wright (*Black Panther*, 2018), Annette Benning (*American Beauty*, 1999) and Branagh himself as detective Hercule Poirot, was an offer he couldn't refuse. To play Katchadourian, a cousin of Gadot's character, Linnet Ridgeway, and, eventually, a murder suspect, Fazal wore prosthetic teeth. "We arrived at these little hacks in order for the British dialect to come a little more naturally and a little more easily," says Fazal. "I could still be s**t. If I fail, I fail, but at least I tried."

Working with Branagh, who is also well-known for his work on stage, Fazal got an opportunity "to study acting". "He is royalty," says Fazal, referring to Branagh's training at the Royal Academy of Dramatic Art. Fazal was also in awe of his director's humility. "Apart from the 11 key characters, there were at least 40 more actors on the ship and he knew everyone by first name. We don't see that anymore," he says of Branagh, a leading contender at this year's Oscars for another film he recently wrote and directed—*Belfast*. "He made little quizzes and chits so that the 11 of us got to know about each other's lives and careers."

What his international co-stars would, perhaps, have learned through these exchanges is that after almost a decade in front of the camera, Fazal became a household name in India thanks to his portrayal of Guddu Bhaiya in the Prime Video series *Mirzapur* (2018—). Many of Guddu's dialogues have become fodder for memes on the internet, highlighting the popularity of the crime drama. Fazal, though, took some time to come to terms with his character's appeal among the country's youth: "I couldn't watch it for a long time because to begin with, it's a very violent show and its infiltration among the younger generation bothered